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SPRING 2022

Homeschooling

and beyond

Tips to
motivate
learning

GAME, SET
AND MATCH

The power
of art

Learning
a second
language

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competition
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20

Hearing health

FAMOUS
HOMESCHOOLERS

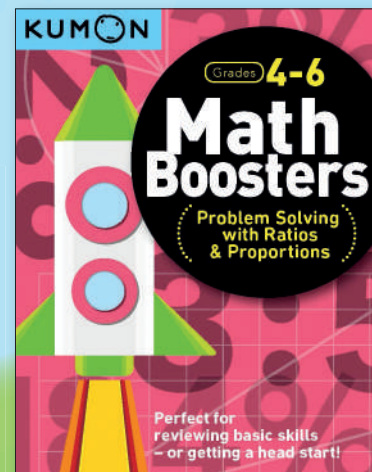
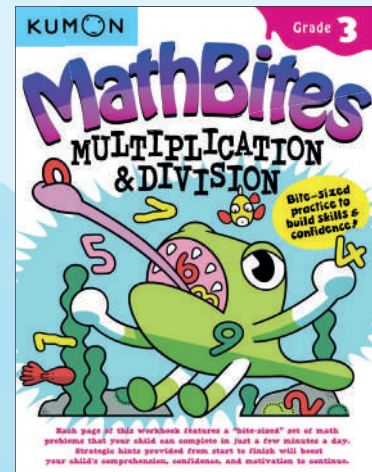
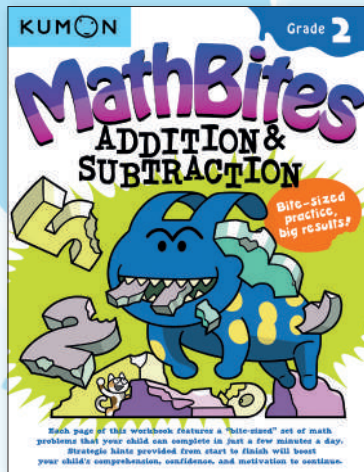
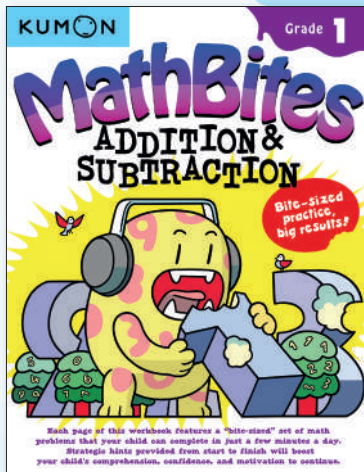
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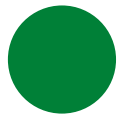
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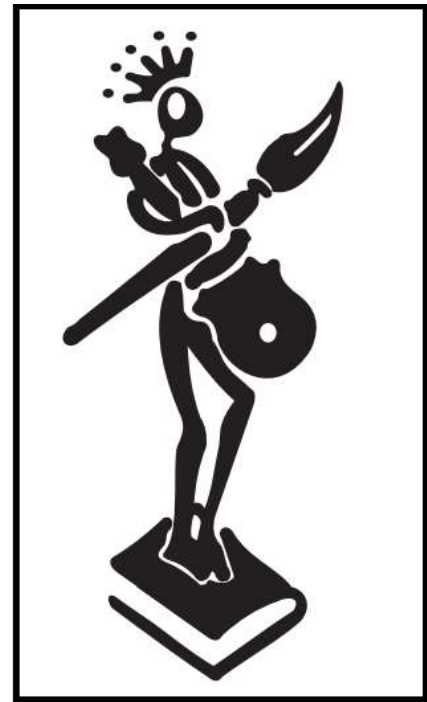
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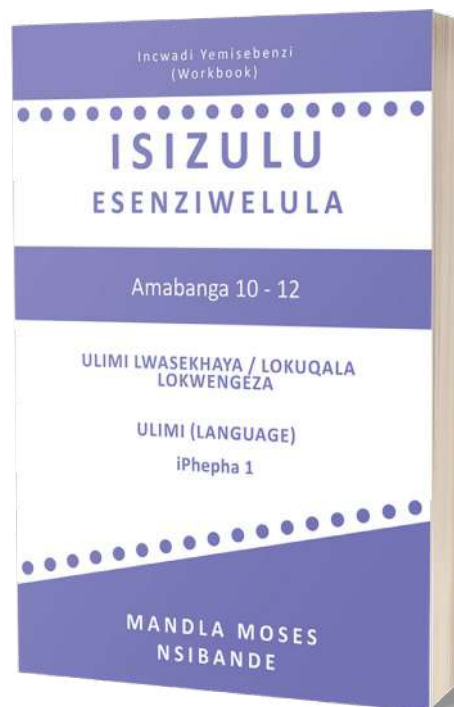
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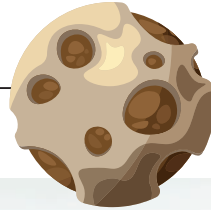
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We moved to a new house last month – and this is to remind those of you who haven't moved recently that it's hard work. Amid the chaos of packing and unpacking, it's also a stressful time, especially if you're like me and depend on routine. What makes it even more challenging is that life doesn't stop when you're moving. You still have work responsibilities, children still have schoolwork and your family still needs to eat. You end up doing most

of the packing once the kids have gone to bed and everything else has been attended to. It. Is. *Tiring!*

It's during moments like these that the adage, "It takes a village to raise a child", rings especially true. I don't remember the first time I heard it, but I do remember how it resonated with me after I became a parent. Before then, I'd never realised just how important that "village" really is or how much I'd depend on it one day.

During our moving process, I had friends drop by to help me pack when our youngest was really sick. My brother helped drive our two eldest to their afternoon activities, my parents brought lunch and my mother-in-law brought supper. My "village" was ready to help where and how they could. And although it's not always easy for me to ask for help, I did, because I had to. Our new house wasn't ready for us to sleep in just yet and my parents were happy to have us while we were busy unpacking and settling in.

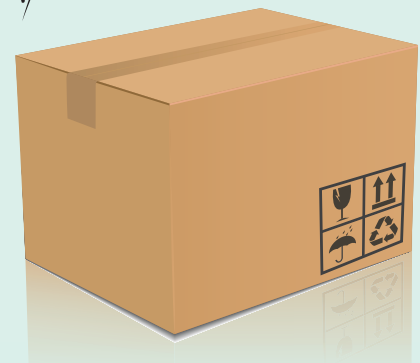
Being a mom has made me deeply grateful for the "village" that's my

constant companion in helping me raise my children. Parenthood is the most challenging (and rewarding) endeavour I've ever experienced. During times such as welcoming a new baby, losing a loved one, coping with illness and other upheavals, I couldn't do it without these supporters. Some days are hard and some weeks are long, but having a village around you makes it all do-able.

I truly hope that every parent is fortunate enough to have a village. If you do, take a moment to tell them how much you appreciate them and be a "villager" for them too, when they need you.

Happy reading!

Adri



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12 fast facts about homeschooling

Wondering whether homeschooling your children is the right choice for your family? Check out these 12 facts

In the past few years, many parents have realised that homeschooling can be a very positive and effective way of educating their children.

Whether you're a new homeschooler or are simply curious about how it works, here are 12 facts that may surprise you:

1 Homeschooling is nothing new! Up until the early 18th century, it was at home that most children were taught by their parents, a tutor or a governess. In 1717, Prussia launched the first compulsory primary school where children sat at desks facing a teacher. The new wave of the homeschool movement started in the 1970s, when John Holt, an educational theorist, argued against rote learning (ie, learning by heart) without understanding the content. He persuaded parents to “unschool” their children and teach them at home.

2 The countries with the most homeschooled children are the USA, the UK, Canada, New Zealand and Australia.

3 In South Africa, credible homeschooling providers follow the same CAPS-aligned curriculum to which every school adheres. These providers are registered with the SA Comprehensive Assessment Institute (SACAI), one of the three examination bodies recognised by Umalusi. Once pupils register with SACAI, they write the same exams as every other pupil in the country and receive a National Senior Certificate upon completing their matric successfully. Bachelor pass-holders are eligible to enrol at any university in South Africa, subject to the requirements of specific faculties.

4 Homeschooled children have access to more subjects than those typically offered in schools. In a traditional school, Grades 10-12 pupils are often limited to only a certain number of subjects or subject combinations, depending on the resources available. However, homeschooling parents are free to structure and modify their children's curriculum as desired, provided they also include the core competencies.

5 Homeschooled children regularly engage in social and educational activities outside their homes and with people other than their nuclear family members.

6 Fewer distractions and no classroom disciplinary issues mean students can focus better and progress at their own pace. Instead of having typical school hours, they have extra time to play, relax, do homework or learn new skills and hobbies.

7 Because homeschooled children have a more flexible schedule, they also have more opportunities to volunteer or get involved in community activities – and that experience has a lasting impact.

8 Parents can determine how involved they want to be. Some programmes do it all and parents only need to supervise. Others give parents a general curriculum which outlines certain concepts kids should master, after which parents run with it. Of course, there are many programmes that fall somewhere in between. Parents can take their own level of education and confidence in teaching their child into account, as well as how much time they have to devote to homeschooling. Many programmes offer more flexibility in parents' involvement.

9 One of the best things about homeschooling is the network into which parents can tap, allowing them to find experts and better equipped teachers than themselves, as well as other homeschooling parents with whom

to share experiences. Workshops, co-ops, classes, online courses and programmes, distance studies – there are many ways in which homeschoolers can learn about something their parents can't teach. Education isn't limited by what a parent knows.

10 Homeschooled children needn't miss out on team activities. The most important team group is the family, where children learn to follow leadership, assume various responsibilities and develop loving and caring relationships that rely on co-operation and consideration. Different team experiences can be offered in sporting groups or activities organised with other homeschooling families.

11 Multiple studies over the past 20 years have found that children who learn at home generally have fewer behavioural problems than their conventionally-schooled counterparts. This is partly because homeschooled kids aren't subject to the peer pressures, rivalry and/or bullying which are prevalent in schoolyards.

12 Research on homeschooling shows that home-educated children achieve well in measures of social, emotional and psychological development such as peer interaction, self-conceptualisation, leadership skills, family cohesion, participation in community service and self-esteem.



Tips to help motivate learning in kids

Do you wish your child would do their work diligently without you nagging? Follow our tips for success!



As parents, we want our children to be successful in whatever they choose to do as adults – and that usually begins (in our minds, anyway) with doing well in school.

Most children, when they first start school, are like sponges: eager to please and soaking up knowledge. However, as they get older, their motivation often wanes and schoolwork becomes a chore.

There are many reasons children's motivation to learn can drop off as they progress through school and beyond. This sometimes happens when a child who's always found something easy suddenly finds it becoming more difficult. Increasing amounts of homework can also play a part. A lack of self-belief can affect children's motivation as well.

If you're struggling to motivate your children, you know by now

that telling them they “need to work harder” doesn't increase their motivation. However, years of research have resulted in some useful strategies that every parent with an unmotivated child needs to know:

Have realistic expectations

Expect your child to succeed and their chances of doing so improve greatly. Equally, expect them to come up short and the odds are just as great that they will. Children are keenly aware of how their parents view them and often tailor their actions to those views, so it's very important to have high (but realistic) expectations – and communicate these to your child. It's equally important to base your expectations on your child's

particular strengths and weaknesses.

Set appropriate expectations by communicating with your child and re-evaluating as necessary. Your child

will grow and change, as will their interests and abilities.

Build up your child's confidence

Give your child opportunities to feel good about themselves, especially the feeling of competence. Whenever your child's curiosity is aroused or they attempt to do something different, ensure that the way you respond makes them feel happy and inspires awe, interest and excitement. They

should come away thinking: “I can do this!”, “It made me happy” and “I can choose what I want to do.” All these make them feel good about themselves.

Develop structure and routines

Structure and routines are crucial to supporting your child. Stability at home gives them the confidence and motivation to apply themselves in their studies.

Often, when you're trying to motivate your children to do something, conflict can arise. Bedtimes, homework completion or social times with their friends can all be sources of contention unless you have established structure and routines in place. Knowing the family's regular schedule and what's expected of them will settle matters. Of course, you have to stick to your own routines and lead by example, but also be willing to be flexible, when the need arises. You're not commanding an army, after all!

Set goals Setting goals can help motivate your child by giving them something to work towards. Research ties setting goals to motivation, self-confidence and autonomy. Get your kids' buy-in of what they want to do. Don't set the goals for them, but ask them questions to help spur a train of thought. Setting goals leads people to accomplish more and the act of writing goals down improves the chance of achieving them by 33%.



Emphasise the process over results Your child could do all the prescribed things and benefit from them, but not necessarily in higher grades. If you only emphasise the end result of the activities, your disappointment may discourage your child from making any further effort. Much like our own experiences as adults, results

don't always reflect the amount of effort that's gone into achieving our goals. Whether or not your child gets high grades, they must see your appreciation of the work they put in. That process alone will have enormous rewards for your child. They'll learn discipline, focus and patience – even if their grades aren't stellar.

“Years of research on motivation have resulted in some useful strategies that every parent needs to know.”



Acknowledge small accomplishments Appreciate even the smallest accomplishments of your children by sharing them with individuals who're important to them. These secure relationships will give them the courage to explore, learn more about their world and increase their understanding of how to function in their environment. Be sincere in your praise.

Be patient Children are a work in progress – and that work can't be fast-forwarded. Inevitable setbacks and disappointments are great opportunities to teach your child and learn for yourself.

ENTER & WIN

It's our 2022 Photographic Competition!

This initiative is aimed at encouraging children to express themselves through photography, inspiring creativity, stimulating the imagination and encouraging artistic skills. There are three age categories, each having its own theme.

Ages 5-10: People

Ages 11-15: Nature

Ages 16-18: Street life

Entries must be e-mailed to:
sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za with
"Photographic Competition" clearly
stated in the subject line along with:

Your full name

Contact number

Child's name and age

Category entered

Title of photograph

The competition will run two issues, this being the first. Every fortnight we'll post a section of entries from each category on our social media pages. Winners' names will be announced in our last issue of the year, online on 14 November.

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GENERAL RULES OF ENTRY 1. The competition is not exclusive to homeschooling children. 2. Entrants must be South African residents. 3. Photos must be supplied in JPG formats and must not exceed a maximum of 3MB. 4. By submitting photographs, you consent to giving SA Homeschooling and Isikhova Media (Pty) Ltd full publishing rights to them.



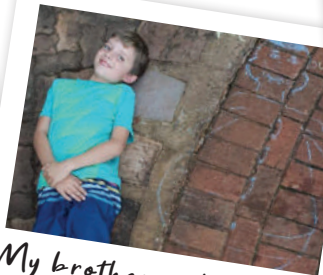
Get snappy!

WOW! Keep on clicking! We're truly impressed by the wonderful and creative entries received so far in our photographic competition. Here are a few. Don't forget to submit yours now. See the opposite page for full details.

Ages 5-10 People



I see you sis!
Kai Brook (7)



My brother in lockdown.
Lea Swanepoel (8)



Grawny's Gnome
('because a gnome
is a person!').
Susan Bates (10)



Amari is my sister.
Reanke Fourie (8)

Ages 11-15 Nature



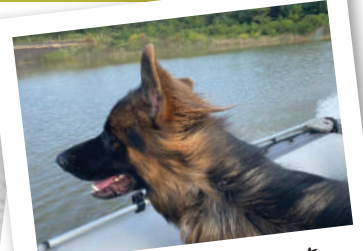
Crystals from Heaven.
Kimaya Valabh (11)



Bitter beginnings.
sweet beginnings.
Nicole Egerton (14)



Cock-a-doodle-do.
Cassandra Timewell (12)



Bowser on a boat.
Anton (11)

Ages 16-18 Street Life



Charlotte's Place.
Dumisane Dube (17)



Yes we can!
Tarryn Fisher (18)



Lucky in Orange Grove.
Viktor Melane (16)



Flight.
Dylan Barkley (18)

Is your child struggling with maths? Here's why



When it comes to mathematics, many parents and children feel anxious and frustrated. This is especially true when a child's struggling with maths despite already getting help in the form of tutoring, extra classes or maths programmes. Dalena van der Westhuizen, cognitive development specialist, master brain coach and co-founder and MD of BrainAbility, shares some insights

Maths. You either love it or hate it.

For most people, their maths anxiety began quite early on during their academic journey. For some, the problems started when having to work at speed, such as during a test or exam. They knew the answers, but their brains froze when up when working against the clock. For others, not understanding the logic in a maths formula was confusing.

Very quickly, they labelled themselves as “not a maths person”. That's usually also when maths anxiety silently becomes an add-on to the label.

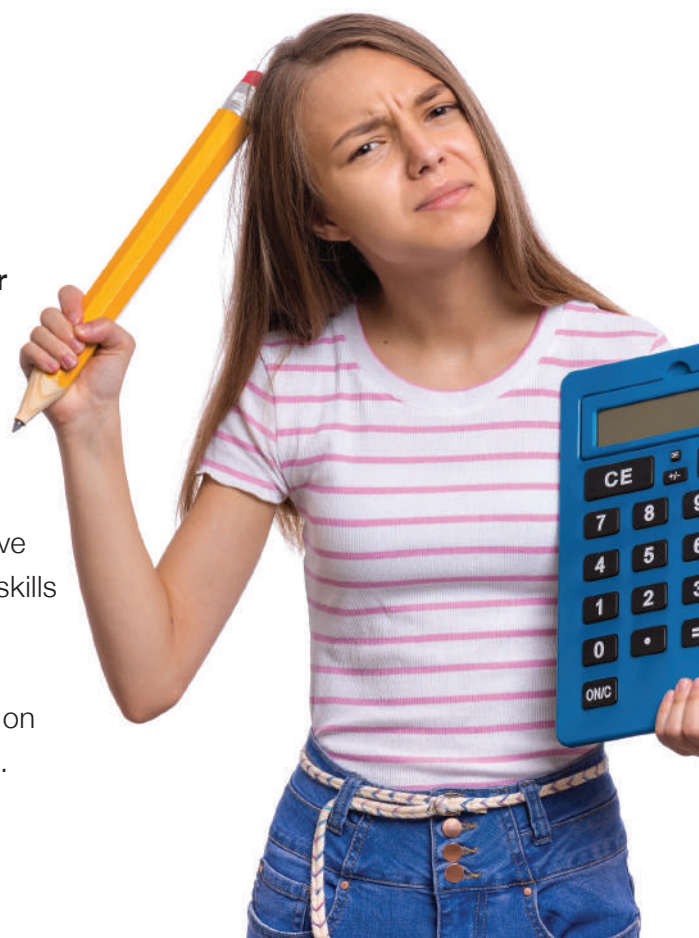
Unfortunately, children who experience maths anxiety often grow up without ever understanding the reason for their maths struggles and carry that

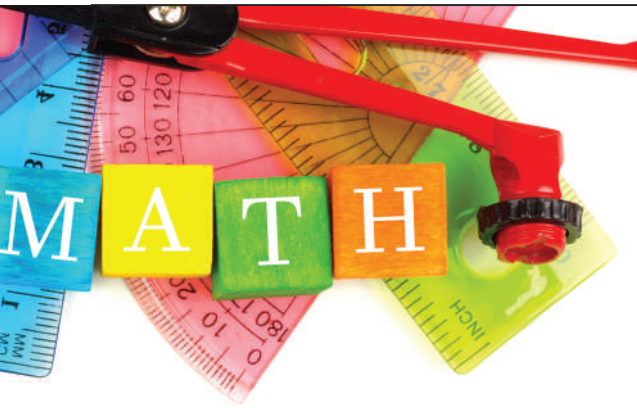
anxiety with them for the rest of their lives. As a parent, they feel helpless when their own child brings home maths homework, asks them a question about it or battles with it just as they did themselves.

Parents' math anxiety and frustration are passed on to their children and so the cycle continues.

Why is maths so difficult for some people? The answer to this question usually lies within the strengths and weaknesses in our individual cognitive profiles. Each of us has strong and weaker cognitive skills – those underlying brain skills essential for learning, reading, reasoning, paying attention, following instructions, thinking on our feet and, yes, doing maths.

Strong cognitive skills are a prerequisite for learning maths. If one or a combination of cognitive skills are weak, they must be strengthened before a child can understand and apply maths.





The connection between cognitive skills and maths

As the foundation for learning, cognitive skills are essential across any academic curriculum.

What, then, are the important underlying cognitive processes that support or impair our learning of maths? According to scientific and educational researchers, mathematical skills can be grouped into the following categories:

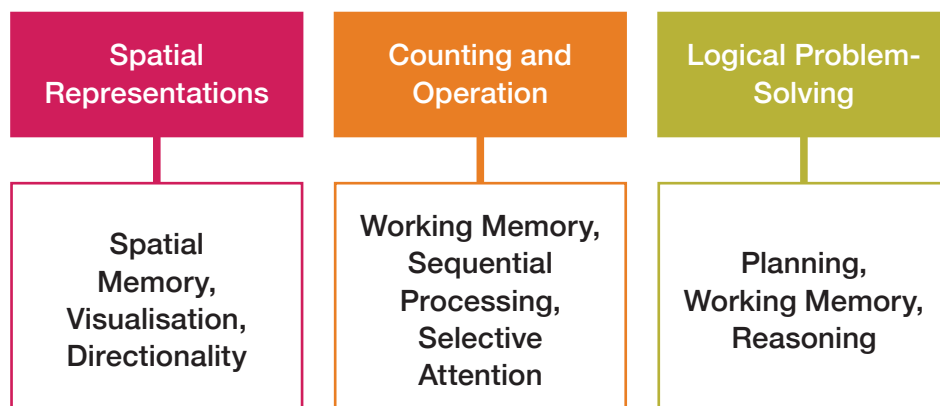
“The best place to start is with a professional cognitive assessment to pinpoint cognitive strengths, weaknesses and individual learning needs.”



somewhat error-prone, but spatial memory (where things are) is associated with correct answers and is thus an important aspect of mathematical problem-solving.

Within visual-spatial processing, we can distinguish cognitive skills such as the following:

COGNITIVE PROCESSES LINKED TO MATHS



Spatial representation

The relationship of maths success to visual-spatial abilities is strongly supported by research and the correlation appears to increase as the complexity of the maths task increases.

The important aspect of visual-spatial processing is not just remembering the shape, size, colour and number of objects, but their relationship to each other in space. It turns out that visual memory by itself (what things are) is

- **Spatial memory:** Our ability to remember where we are in space and how we’re related to other objects in space. This understanding provides the foundation on which



problems (changes in the space) can be solved.

- **Visualisation:** Our ability to visualise a problem we need to solve or to visualise alternative solutions contributes substantially to our understanding of the problem.

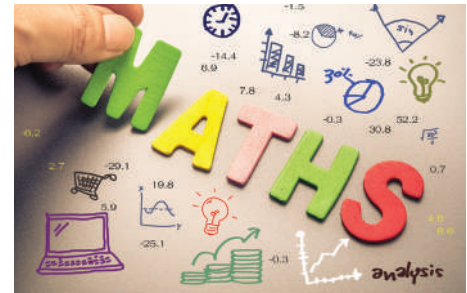


- **Directionality:** The ability to distinguish between left and right, of course, is more than just about maths. It's essential for everyday tasks like tying shoelaces, reading a map, driving and playing sport.

Counting and operations

When it comes to counting and numerical operations, we're again dependent for maths success on some foundational cognitive skills:

- **Working memory:** Our ability to hold information in our minds while we manipulate it. Working memory capacity is highly correlated with reading comprehension, maths performance and many other



academic and non-academic outcomes.

- **Sequential processing:** Counting is all about sequences, so once again, cognitive skills contribute crucially at even the most elementary stages of maths. As we start to manipulate and calculate, the sequence of steps to solve a problem must be observed.



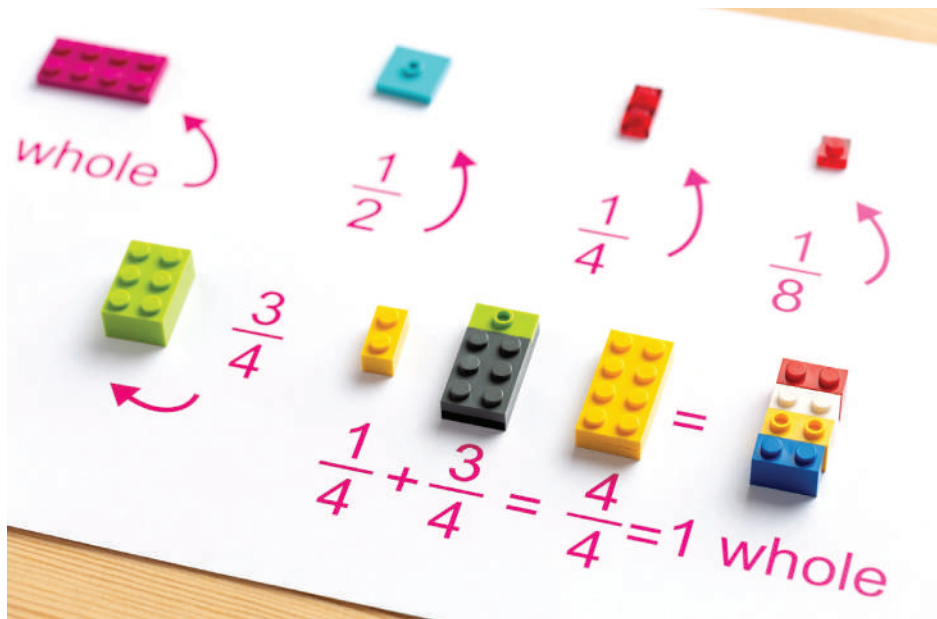
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• **Selective attention:** When we have good selective attention skills, it's easier for us to screen out the irrelevant parts of a complex problem and isolate the relevant facts on which we need to concentrate.

Logical problem-solving

Undoubtedly, maths is problem-solving. There are, of course, other types of problem-solving, but problems with numbers almost always call for mathematical thinking and logic to be applied.

Higher-order cognitive processes are often required to be successful in maths. These include:

• **Planning:** Good planning is when we consider alternative approaches to a problem, map out the sequence of steps in advance and then carry them out efficiently and accurately.

• **Working memory:** Consider the example of a child who's always struggling to finish her

maths classwork, tests or homework. She might understand the core concepts of what she has to do, but she has limited working memory capacity. When she has to copy a problem from her maths book into her homework book (eg 267×3), she has to copy each number by itself: first the 2, then the 6, etc. She can't remember 267, much less the entire maths problem. Working memory is essential to hold the elements of any maths problem in mind, consider different approaches and keep track of where we are in a sequence of steps to solve a multi-step mathematical problem.

• **Logic and reasoning:** As we learn about mathematical theories or explain how we draw conclusions, we have to recognise patterns, analyse cause and effect, test hypotheses and determine whether to include or exclude items from sets. For all of these, we rely heavily on our logic and reasoning ability.

As we acknowledge how critical cognitive skills are to maths and learning, it raises the question of how we can support our children in developing these skills so that they can be effective students. The best place to start is with a professional cognitive assessment to pinpoint cognitive strengths, weaknesses and individual learning needs.

“Children who experience maths anxiety often grow up without ever understanding the reason for their maths struggles and carry that anxiety with them for the rest of their lives.”

I ♥ Math





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20

famous people you didn't know were homeschooled

Homeschooling was the earliest form of education and many famous people were educated that way. Check out our list of 20 of them

Famous homeschoolers? Of course! Throughout history there've been many notable people – from politicians, authors and artists to sportspeople, entrepreneurs and inventors – who were educated at home. Here are 20 of them:



◀ **JRR Tolkien**
Famous author John Ronald Reuel Tolkien, who wrote *The*

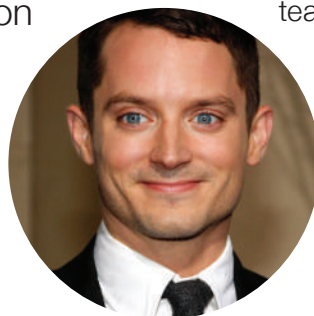
Hobbit and *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy, was homeschooled until the age of 12, when his mother passed away.

▶ **Simone Biles** Considered one of the greatest women gymnasts the USA has ever produced, Biles actually attended public school until the age of 13. However, by then, her gymnastic career was in full bloom, so she was removed from the public school routine so that she had the time and freedom to



balance her gymnastic career with her studies.

△ **The Jonas Brothers** Rock group brothers Nick, Joe and Kevin Jonas were schooled at home by their mother Denise, a devout Christian who felt that teaching her sons herself was a better option than entrusting their education to others.



◀ **Elijah Wood**
Elijah Wood started out as a child actor and due to the demands of his burgeoning film career, he began homeschooling at the age of eight.





Theodore Roosevelt

Because Roosevelt – the 26th President of the USA, as well as his 13 other siblings – suffered from many maladies, they were all homeschooled. They were tutored by their mother, an aunt and their French governess.

▷ Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart

Prolific Austrian composer Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, born in 1756, was homeschooled by his father. Mozart composed his first classical work at the age of five, began performing for audiences (including royalty) on the piano at the age of six and composed his first opera at the age of 11. He spent much of his childhood touring Europe, with his father tutoring him in music and other subjects.

His sister Maria Anna (“Nannerl”), who was an equally gifted performer, was also educated this way while touring and performing.



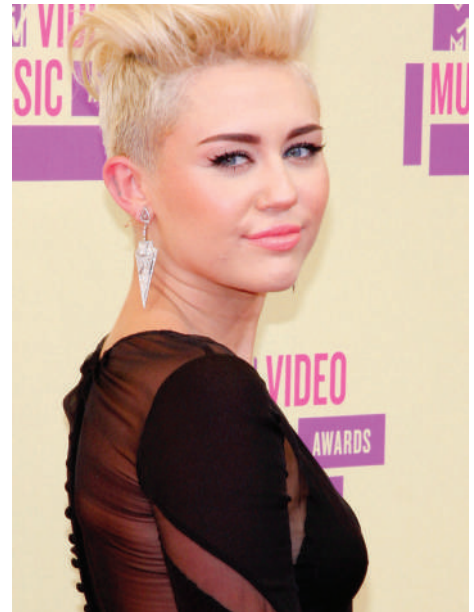
◁ Thomas Edison

This American businessman and inventor was continually in trouble at school – so much so that at the age of seven, his mother, who was herself a schoolteacher, removed him from public school so that she could teach him at home.



◁ **Ryan Gosling** After being bullied at school and struggling with attention deficit-hyperactivity disorder, Gosling was removed from mainstream school at the age of 10 by his mother. Despite being a single parent, she successfully educated him at home.

▷ **Ansel Adams** The famous photographer was taken out of traditional school when he was 12 and homeschooled by a private tutor.



△ **Miley Cyrus** The singer, songwriter and actress – known for her raspy voice – actually graduated from high school early because she had been homeschooled.

Laura Ingalls Wilder Author Laura Ingalls Wilder, best known for her *Little House on the Prairie* series, was homeschooled. The family moved often, but wherever they went, one-roomed



schoolhouses were usually too far to reach or inaccessible because of weather.

Demi Lovato The singer and former Disney star left traditional school because of bullying and started homeschooling when she was 12.

▷ **Venus and Serena Williams**

Well before they became grand slam tennis champions, the Williams sisters were schooled by their father Richard.



▷ **Taylor Swift** A superstar at only 14 years of age, singer-songwriter Taylor no longer had time to attend school regularly and decided to pursue homeschooling. With the help of tutors, she studied so far ahead that she graduated from high school early.



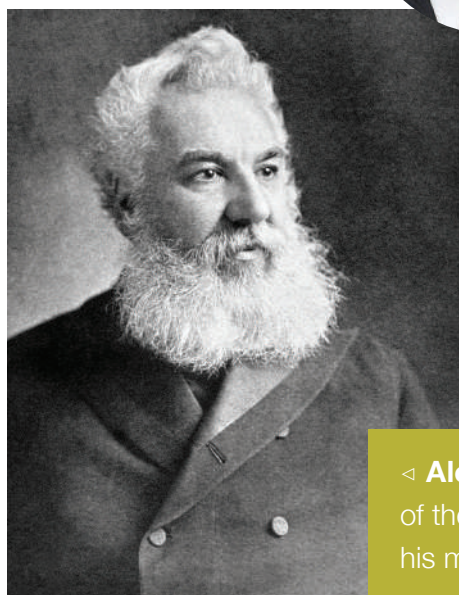
Christopher Paolini

Christopher Paolini, who holds the Guinness World Record as the youngest author to pen a best-selling book series (*The Inheritance Cycle*), was homeschooled for his entire academic career.



△ **Justin Timberlake**

Timberlake initially attended public school, but when he was cast in Disney's *The Mickey Mouse Club*, his filming commitments prevented him attending classes regularly. From sixth grade to graduation, he was homeschooled.



◁ **Alexander Graham Bell** The inventor of the telephone was homeschooled by his mother until he was 11.



CS Lewis Author of the highly imaginative *Chronicles of Narnia* series, Lewis spent a great deal of his youth being homeschooled by private tutors. He went on to become an influential thought leader, an esteemed teacher and a respected theologian.



△ **Emma Watson** The English actress and model was homeschooled during her *Harry Potter* years.

The next time you doubt your decision to homeschool, remind yourself of all these notables who went on to achieve great things. Stay the course, dream big, expect success and work hard!



Jozi-X extreme adventures

Catering for super-active kids and adults from the age of five to 75, [Jozi-X](#) offers loads of physical fun for fans of extreme adventures. Located at the corner of Main Road and Sloane Street in Bryanston, Johannesburg, it offers activities such as mountain boarding, a slackline park, big-wheel trike drifting, a parkour gymnasium, a “ninja centre” and the star attraction: an extreme wipeout course. Entry is free of charge and prices of activities vary.

Phezulu Cultural Village and Reptile Park

Discover the incredible heritage of South Africa’s Zulu people with a visit to [Phezulu Cultural Village and Reptile Park](#) in KZN’s Valley of 1 000 Hills. The park is known for its traditional beehive-shaped huts and hands-on experiences like Zulu spear-making and colourful Zulu dancing. Take an informative tour of the park’s reptile

portion, where you’ll learn first-hand about crocodiles and snakes, including the notorious green mamba.

Pinboard

Fun local events and outdoor activities in your city and nearby places for the whole family



The Big Red Barn

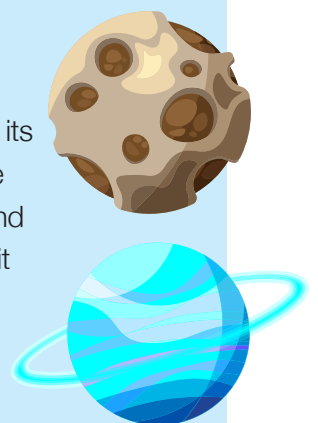
Set across the Sunlawns Estate farm built on 200ha of land, a 15-minute drive from Centurion, [The Big Red Barn](#) offers an array of activities plus a family-friendly café where you can host a kids’ party. Activities include a tree-top Acrobranch adventure

course, a kids’ cycle park (with bikes for rental), go-karting at the Vroom Pedal Go-Karts area or letting the kids find their inner Picasso at the Clay Café while painting ceramic objects. The Big Red Barn is open Wednesday-Sunday, as well as on public holidays and school holidays.



Iziko Planetarium and Digital Dome

The [planetarium](#) has undergone a 21st-century makeover with its Digital Dome, making it the most advanced planetarium on the African continent, providing both multi-sensory edutainment and cutting-edge scientific research facilities. With its 360° screen, it makes virtual voyages of the entire universe possible. Located at 25 Queen Victoria Street in Cape Town, it offers four shows, two of them specifically geared towards children. This year, kids can join Tycho the space dog on his trip to the moon.



Exciting new offerings with UCT Online High School coming in 2023

It's hard to believe that it's already been a year since UCT Online High School launched. With over 5 000 learners and over 600 staff, it's come a long way since then. Today UCT Online High School is a thriving, evolving institution, more determined than ever to change the face of education in Africa. Which is why it's thrilled to share two exciting new offerings with you, coming in 2023



(Above): UCT Vice-Chancellor Professor Mamokgethi Phakeng.



UCT Online High School is now the most affordable, fully accredited online school in Africa to offer the Cambridge International curriculum — for only R3 300 per month.

As one of the most renowned educational institutions on the planet, Cambridge has a proud history of excellence and innovation, having refined its school curriculum for the past 160 years. Currently, the **Cambridge Assessment International Education** is offered in over 10 000 schools in more than 160 countries with more than 8

million learners writing their Cambridge International examinations every year.

Recognised by over 2 000 tertiary institutions worldwide, upon completion, UCT Online High School learners will automatically be eligible to apply to any university in the United Kingdom, over 800 universities in the United States, and many other learner destinations, including Canada, Australia, Singapore, Germany and the Netherlands. Not to mention all major tertiary institutions within southern Africa and throughout Africa.

UCT Online High School is proud to provide learners within South Africa, and beyond its borders, the opportunity to complete the

following qualifications: IGCSE (from 2023) and International AS-Levels and A-Levels (from 2025).

The Cambridge International curriculum is a powerful academic passport to a brighter, global future for many aspiring young Africans. UCT Online High School's current cohort of learners will continue to spread across Africa into the world, taking advantage of this growing global network and expanding their world views through friendships they would have never been exposed to in their own immediate communities.

Join this thriving online community today for R3 300 per month.

Adult Matric

Another exciting offering coming from UCT Online High School in 2023 is the Adult Matric programme. Delivered entirely online, Adult Matric will provide a second chance to those learners who were unable, or never given the opportunity, to write their South African National Senior Certificate when they were young — because it's never too late to enable a better future for you and your family.

As per Youth Capital's research, almost one third of all people working towards their matric certificate do so outside the full-time, in-school system. As second-chancers, the educational journeys of these non-traditional learners often go unrecognised. UCT Online High School is there to celebrate and support these learners. UCT



Online High School Adult Matric offers a viable and affordable alternative for adults to study online, and part-time, towards attaining their all-important matric certificate.

Head to the [website](#) and sign up to get more information on these exciting new products!

You are UCT

You see, UCT Online High School isn't just a school – it's the backbone of an entire ecosystem which has been designed to service learners from a broad range of socio-economic and academic means.

Join UCT Online High School for CAPS, Cambridge International or Adult Matric!

Enrol by 31 Oct 22 to receive a discount on your placement fee.

For more information, head to uctonlinehighschool.com and download an info pack. Alternatively, book a call with one of our friendly Admissions Consultants on +27 21 140 1792, or e-mail: admissions@uctohs.valentureonline.com and they'll be sure to answer any questions you may have.

Why tennis is a great choice for kids

Tennis provides countless physical benefits for children and is an ace for helping them work on focus and critical thinking. Each shot requires them to make technical and tactical choices. Lindsay Viljoen of the Lindsay Viljoen Tennis Academy tells us more



Tennis has long been embedded in the South African sporting culture and provides health and lifestyle benefits to all ages.

“If you’re wanting to introduce your child to a sport, tennis is a great option on many levels,” says Lindsay. “It’s both physically and mentally rigorous, promoting both strong psychological and physiological development.”

Lindsay comes from a tennis-playing family and was fortunate enough to have a tennis court at home. As one of four children, she loved playing doubles with her three brothers. Her parents, especially her mother, also enjoyed playing tennis and often joined them on the court. “I have many fond memories of us playing together as a family. That’s where my love for the sport comes from,” she says.



Today Lindsay coaches children from as young as four and has a number of adult players who come for lessons too. “Tennis is an excellent sport for young athletes and offers several hidden benefits that aren’t often found in other popular sports,” she says.

She shares six reasons for encouraging kids to play tennis:

- **It’s social and fun** Surprise! Tennis is actually a great social sport. At first glance, it may seem like a solitary activity, comprising only two or four players, unlike team sports such as soccer, rugby, netball, basketball or cricket. However, tennis provides a great social outlet for young athletes. Lifetime friendships are often made in tennis clubs at school and in adulthood. It’s also a great way of meeting people.

- **Low risk for injury** Safety first! High-contact sports like soccer and rugby are favourites among youngsters, but they’re notorious for producing injuries. While all of these activities are excellent ways of exercising and building team spirit, they involve many bruises and falls, as well as the risk of more serious injuries. With tennis, while shoelace trips and strains may occur, their likelihood is minimised with practice and patience.

- **Physical development** Perhaps the most obvious benefit of tennis for your child is

physical development. The game involves a lot of running around, quick movements and the use of the entire body. As a result, the development of muscular body strength is inevitable. Couple this with the strengthening of the cardiovascular system and you’re looking at the perfect workout.

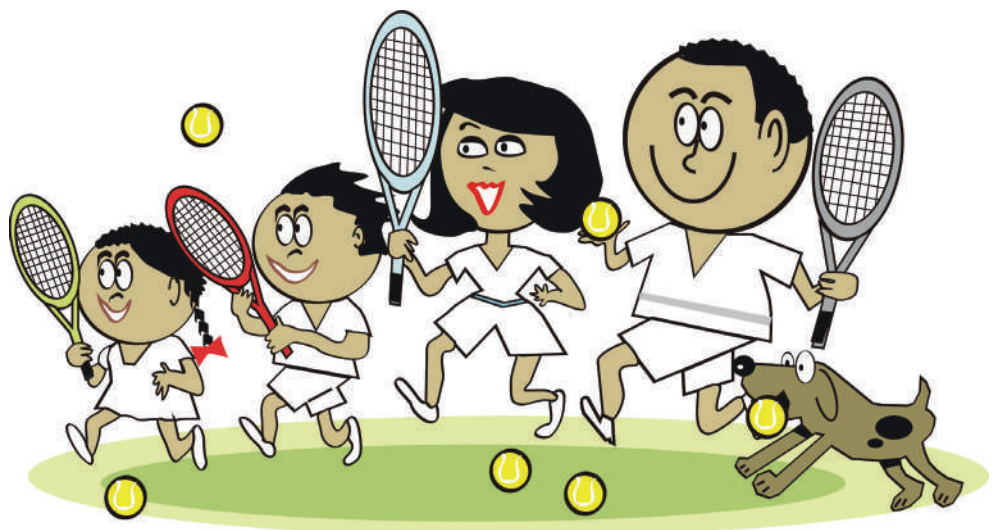
- **Mental development** The game is more complicated than most sports and the necessity of building strategic thinking skills on



“If your clan’s looking for a way to spend more quality time together, consider this issue’s favourite sport.”

the tennis court often accelerates a child’s ability to problem-solve. As a result, many children show accelerated mental development in the frontal lobe of their brain – the section associated with reasoning, planning and problem-solving. In other words, tennis is good for your child’s mental development, both on and off the tennis court.

- **Cross-training** Kids who play and compete in virtually any other sport can use tennis as a way of cross-training. It enhances flexibility, speed, agility, balance, eye-hand co-ordination, core strength and endurance.



• **Life skills** Tennis teaches kids self-confidence, discipline, patience, respect for competitors and self-control. In addition, they learn how to handle challenges and adjust to circumstances.

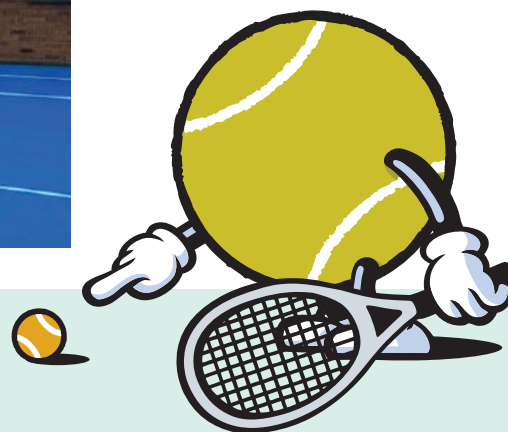
“Tennis is also one of the few sports where physical stature means relatively little,” adds Lindsay. “In rugby, a player’s strength or mobility matters. In

soccer, a player’s flexibility and agility matter. In tennis, all of those physical qualities matter, but because the sport’s such a mental endeavour, no one physical trait stands out demonstrably. There’s no single qualifying or disqualifying characteristic in tennis.”

Widely recognised as one of the most popular sports in the world, tennis is played by an estimated

1,17% of the world’s population. In fact, when analysing Google Trends Data for tennis compared with other sports at a global level, it appears to be significantly ahead in terms of its search interest. It certainly delivers on the two vital Fs – fun and fitness – and it’s fairly inexpensive, compared with many other sports. All that’s required is a racquet (beginners’ ones are modestly priced), takkies and some tennis balls.

So what are you waiting for? Get out there and think Wimbledon!



A family who plays together stays together

There’s something extra-special about a family who plays tennis together. If your clan’s looking for a way to spend more quality time together, consider this issue’s favourite sport.

As children become more independent, it’s easy for family members to drift apart. Tennis gives kids and adults alike a reason to get excited about coming together.

“One of the greatest benefits of tennis is lifelong playtime,” says Lindsay. “Athletes of all ages enjoy many different kinds of sports, but some activities have a longer ‘shelf life’ than others. Tennis is a great sport because your child can play it even

after leaving school or university – and there’s no reason why parents can’t join them on the court.

“I arrange fun parent-child tournaments every couple of months. It not only gives parents the opportunity to see their child’s progress, but also encourages them to dust off their takkies and get moving. It’s something that both kids and parents look forward to and most carry on playing long after the scheduled time.”

Tennis is also guaranteed to include laughter and lessons in co-operation and appreciation. If you need a little help getting started, there are many tennis clubs available with great programmes that will help launch your new family activity.



GOLD

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Ask Dalena

Dalena van der Westhuizen will answer any questions or concerns you may have about learning, concentration, memory and cognitive development – and, of course, the frustrations arising from these



My nine-year-old son has ADHD and is on short-acting medication. By the time I get home from work in the afternoons, it's quite late and there's usually still homework with which I need to help him. Do you have any suggestions/tips for keeping him engaged without having to "top him up" with medication just to do the schoolwork? – *Anonymous*

Hi anonymous,

I wish I had an easy answer for you. Trying to help a tired, unfocused nine-year-old who needs to finish schoolwork that he doesn't like or understand is, in my opinion, on a par with trying to hop through the desert on one leg. It. Is. *Hard*.

My suggestion would be to create an ADHD-friendly study environment. Here are some tips for doing that:

- Have room for movement. When your son feels restless, encourage him to get up and



move around. Don't force him to sit still in front of a desk/table.

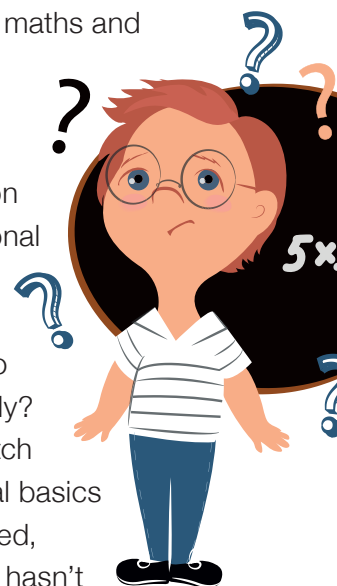
- Set a timer for 15-25 minutes, then allow a five-minute break when he can jump on a trampoline or do a set of jumping jacks – any type of physical activity that works best for him.
- ADHD brains need to be actively engaged with what they're learning. They also need to find creative ways to learn. The more they engage with a subject, the more information they'll retain. Break down difficult concepts or multi-step projects into smaller chunks, then think of real-world applications of the concepts he's learning.

- Also try using visual tools, pictures, drawings, stories, etc to make a concept/information less abstract. The more interactive the learning approach, the more focused your son will be.

My child performs well in every subject – except maths. Because of this, he tends to focus on the subjects in which he's proficient and spends little time practising or studying maths. How can I change his mind about this? – *Cherese, Polokwane*

Hi Cherese,

When it comes to learning struggles, especially maths and avoidance, I always focus on finding the *why* behind the struggle. Did your son miss some foundational maths concepts and information that he now needs to understand and apply? If so, helping him catch up with mathematical basics (academics) he missed, didn't understand or hasn't



yet mastered should sort out the problem. In that case, a maths tutor or extra maths lessons would be the answer.

However, if he struggles with maths because one or more of the underlying cognitive skills needed to do it is weak, no amount of tutoring, study methods, motivation or extra classes will make a real difference. Any weak cognitive skill(s) should be strengthened before he's able to catch up and keep up with his maths work.

Cognitive skills are the brain skills we rely on to process, store, recall and apply information.

Be sure to read the article *Is Your Child Struggling With Maths? Here's Why* on page 12, where you can learn more about the link between cognitive skills and maths.

I've been homeschooling my 15-year-old daughter since the beginning of the year. She works hard and has always performed well. However, I've noticed that she's growing increasingly anxious about her schoolwork since we started homeschooling. How can I help allay her anxiety?
– Lynne, *Fourways*

Hi Lynne,

For many children, transitioning from a "normal" school environment to a homeschooling environment is a gradual process

that takes a while and at times may feel slightly overwhelming.

Over the years, I've learnt from kids we work with in our cognitive development centres that some of them feel a deep responsibility for their "success" with homeschooling, which could cause anxiety. Others have always wished for more independence, yet they struggle with the time management skills and self-regulation required when moving from a very controlled in-school environment to a more relaxed homeschooling one.

Others miss the structure of a school environment, having their own age group around them, or they miss comparing their progress and academic successes with those of their classmates.

Though teenagers aren't always willing to share their feelings openly, try talking to your daughter about her homeschooling experience so far and ask what advice she'd give to high school kids considering



About Dalena

Dalena van der Westhuizen is the co-founder and MD of BrainAbility, a cognitive development specialist, a master brain coach and an internationally certified cognitive coach. She translates the latest international cognitive research and best practice into strategies that can be applied by parents and educators alike.

A mom and a self-confessed chocoholic, Dalena enjoys working with both kids and adults to improve the way their brains process information for better learning, reading and focusing.

Send your questions for Dalena to: adri@isikhova.co.za.

doing it. Also ask her what she'd do differently if she could. That conversation will hopefully provide a few clues to the reason(s) for her anxiety and ways of addressing them.

Homeschooling is a journey and what works for one family doesn't necessarily work for another, so be willing to implement some of her suggestions.

How **art** helps children thrive

In recent years, curricula have shifted heavily towards common core subjects of reading and maths, but what about the arts? Learning to create and appreciate visual aesthetics may be more important than ever to the development of the next generation of children

While many parents view art as a hobby for kids, it can actually be essential to a child's early education.

Popular theories in this field suggest that children's artistic abilities are often underestimated and that when given opportunities to explore artistic practice and creative thinking, they generally have stronger outcomes in other subjects such as science and maths.

Engaging in art experiences benefits all aspects of children's development. As they progress into elementary school and beyond, art continues to provide opportunities for brain development, mastery, self-esteem and creativity.

Creating art expands a child's ability to interact with the world around them, as well as expanding and stimulating their imagination and providing a new set of skills for self-expression and communication. Not only does art help to develop the right side of the brain, but it goes far beyond the tangible statistics measured by studies – it can become a pivotal mode of uninhibited self-expression and amazement for a child. Art matters in the same way that language matters. It's a fundamental component of what makes us uniquely human.

The benefits of art for children

Fine motor skills: Grasping pencils, crayons, chalk and paintbrushes helps children develop their fine motor muscles.



This development helps a child with writing and other tasks that require controlled movements. According to the National Institutes of Health, developmental milestones around the age of three should include drawing a circle and beginning to use safety scissors. Around the age of four, kids may be able to draw a square and begin cutting straight lines



with scissors. Many pre-school programmes emphasise the use of scissors because it develops the dexterity children will need for writing.

Cognitive development: Art can help children learn and practise skills like patterning and cause and effect (ie: “If I push very hard with a crayon, the colour it gives is darker.”). They can also practise critical thinking skills by making a mental plan or picture of what they intend to create and following through on it.

Language skills: Children love to describe their artwork and if not, they should be encouraged to do so. Talking about artwork and forming short stories based on them can introduce children to sentence formation, sequencing and new vocabulary. If a child’s too young to describe the artwork, parents can build their own stories about their creations.

Mathematical skills: Art also helps children grasp concepts like counting, size, shape, making comparisons and promoting

spatial reasoning. A study published by the National Art Education Association stressed these benefits.

Decision-making: Art education strengthens problem-solving and critical thinking skills. The experience of making decisions and choices in the course of creating art carries over into other parts of life. “If they’re exploring, experimenting and trying new ideas, then creativity has a chance to blossom,” says MaryAnn Kohl,

“When given opportunities to explore artistic practice and creative thinking, children generally have stronger outcomes in other subjects such as science and maths.”

an arts educator and author of numerous books on children’s art education.

Visual learning: Drawing, sculpting with clay and threading beads on a string all develop visual-spatial skills. Even toddlers know how to operate a smartphone or tablet, which means that well before they can read, kids are already taking in visual information, consisting of clues from pictures or three-dimensional objects from digital media, books and TV.

Freedom of expression: A blank canvas has unlimited possibilities. As far as children are concerned, their imaginations are limitless and can gather the most insightful, raw and truthful impressions of life. Whether the art is abstract or just colourful scribbling, your child has a lot to tell you.



Cultural awareness: Since we live in an increasingly diverse society, the images of different groups in the media may also present mixed messages. Teaching children to recognise the choices an artist or designer makes in portraying a subject helps kids understand that what they see may only be someone's interpretation of reality, rather than an objective truth.

Neural connections: Art is an activity that can employ all the senses – sight, sound, touch, smell and taste. Children's brain synapses fire away as they experiment and create by squishing paint between their fingers, mixing colours and materials, or drawing from imagination or what they see in front of them.



Helps kids connect: Art is an equaliser, helping create a common ground for children who don't know each other and who may or may not be interested in the same things. It can help people of all ages, races, abilities and even

languages engage in a shared (and generally mutually loved) activity. The path to an art-filled life involves an open mind, a few simple tools, a bit of preparation and an exploratory approach.

Relieves stress: Children suffer from stress, anxiety and uncertainty too. They have unique ways of expressing their feelings, especially distress. Younger ones may throw tantrums or fuss, while older kids may become assertive or withdrawn. Art becomes the secret language of children to express and understand feelings they generally find difficult to talk about to others. Child psychologist Dr Lawrence Shapiro, in his book *The Secret Language of Children: How to Understand What Your Kids are Really Saying* (Sourcebooks), writes that children use art as a “bandage” for psychological pain.

Encourage your child to explore the arts by giving them a space where they can make a mess. Simply lay out old rags and sheets on the floor and let them use the space however they wish. It's also important not to direct them: don't tell them what to make or how to make it. Simply encourage them to experiment with colours and materials. The purpose of art experiences is to allow children to explore on their own, using materials in their own ways. This teaches them that their own abilities are valued and motivates them to participate freely in creating art.



Learning a second language: The benefits

Studies have shown that bilingual children are faster learners, more creative, have improved problem-solving skills and more career opportunities in adulthood

In South Africa, there are ample advantages to being bilingual or multilingual. We live in a culturally rich country with 11 official languages and learning a second language will allow your child to connect more easily with other cultures.

It's never too late (or too early) to learn a second language. Children are like sponges, with their brains designed to absorb new information subconsciously. They do this similarly to the way that we, as adults, subconsciously learn song lyrics, rhythms and melodies.

*Praat
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Children also think in a much simpler way than adults. They use fewer words, simpler sentence structures and think less abstractly. This allows them to learn a new language more easily, since they don't have to express

"If you want to create a brainiac, teaching your child another language is the way to go!"



themselves in a complex way. They also have more time to learn the language and develop their skills as they grow.

Children who learn a second language have significant advantages over those who only learn their mother tongue. If you want to create a brainiac, teaching your child another language is the way to go!

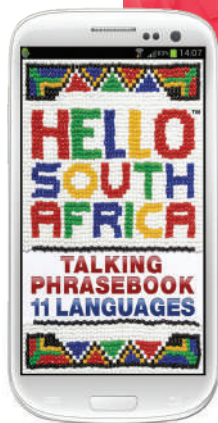
Being able to speak more than one language is really good for the brain, say researchers.

Johan Mårtensson's research shows that after three months of studying a new language, students' brains grew in four places: the hippocampus, the middle frontal gyrus, the inferior frontal gyrus and the superior temporal gyrus.



According to research conducted by Julia Morales of Spain's Granada University, children who learn a second language also have better recall and retention than speakers of just one language. In 1962, Peal and Lambert published a study in which they had found that people who were at least conversationally fluent in more than one language consistently beat monolinguals on tests of verbal and non-verbal intelligence. Research further shows a high positive correlation between foreign language study and improved reading scores.

Monolingual speakers usually have only a superficial understanding of grammar and may be able to identify an adjective or a gerund. The reason is that they simply don't require that knowledge, other than for school tests. However, learning a second language draws attention to the



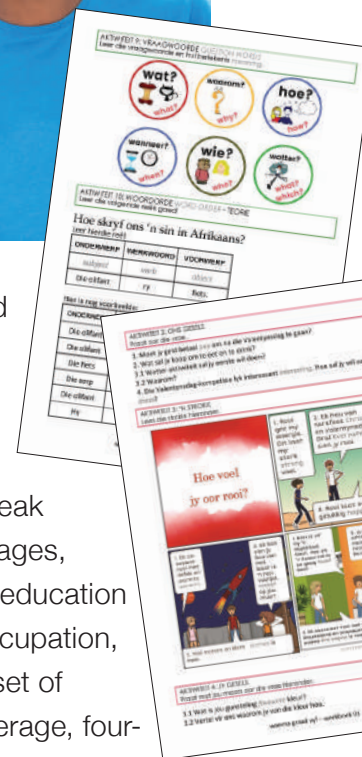
abstract rules and structure of language, thus making children better at their first language too.

It sounds like a cliché, but the reality is that a person's chances of employment in today's economy can be better for those who speak more than only one language. Multilingual employees are able to communicate and interact within multiple communities. With the rise of technology, which enables global communication, such an ability

becomes more and more valuable.

Research has also found that individuals who speak two or more languages, regardless of their education level, gender or occupation, experience the onset of Alzheimer's, on average, four-and-a-half years later than monolingual subjects.

Children who learn a second language eventually become



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better at problem-solving and creativity, since their brains experience a constant workout from a young age as they try to sort out which language to speak, when and with whom. They're also better at planning, concentrating and multi-tasking.

Bilingual children learn to see the world from different perspectives. This makes them more diversified and better at critical thinking, as every new language we learn presents us with new obstacles in terms of conveying meaning.

Learning a new language is rewarding at any age, but children benefit from it when they're still very young. Studies particularly support starting bilingual education at pre-school level, when children easily (and subconsciously) pick up vocabulary, sentence construction and idiomatic usage.

It's clear that starting your child on the path of second language acquisition offers many advantages, so begin today!



Keep it fun!



Cecile Smith worked as a qualified teacher for 25 years teaching Afrikaans first additional language. She realised the need for integrating language theory and practical exercises for her pupils, which led her to develop the Afrikaans work- and textbooks *Woemaboeke*, which are fun and creative, while also including theory and revision exercises.

1 She shares six ways to motivate additional language students:

Use visual cues Research has shown that visual elements help to learn new concepts and motivate students. For example, the *Woemaboeke* series is printed in full colour and also has posters available that can visually enhance a study area with illustrated idioms, language rules, etc.

2 Be relevant to their world Students are more comfortable chatting about a subject they like. Themes like "This is my story" or "Bullies" are bound to get them talking and involved.

3 Make the language fun Your students need to look forward to learning! An anxious student can't learn and remember

new words or concepts. Smith and Smith uses creativity to keep both students and educators engaged – for example, with word games, word searches and other creative ice-breakers. These will help students feel more comfortable. It's easier to speak a second language in a relaxed environment. The more students practise speaking it, the more confident they become.

4 Students must write and speak it Take small steps. Students will become nervous to speak if they're not armed with the right tools to do so. Write keywords on the board and ask students to form sentences with them.

5 Simplify the way language structures are taught Language theory is important. For example, *Woemaboeke* follows the same pattern from Grades 3-12. Each theme starts with vocabulary that needs to be learnt well. After the introduction of each new language concept, exercises follow which are answered directly in the workbooks.

6 Revise, revise, revise! Learning a new language can be overwhelming. It's key that students revise what they've been taught.

Get the braai sizzling for spring

Spring is here – and what better way to celebrate than with a tasty green bean salad, home-made honey-thyme bread and beef fillet with mushroom stuffing on the coals for the perfect braai?

Dust off the braai grid and try these easy and tasty recipes that the whole family can help prepare from chef and mom-of-four Anri Fourie.

GREEN BEAN SALAD WITH GARLIC AND PARMESAN

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 15 mins

Ingredients

600g trimmed green beans, cut into 2cm pieces

½ red onion (or 1 shallot)

¾ cup (75g) freshly grated Parmesan cheese

Salt and freshly ground black pepper

60ml (4T) olive oil

2 lemons, freshly squeezed, with zest finely grated

5ml (1 tsp) fresh chopped garlic

10ml (2 tsp) mayonnaise

What else you will need

A medium-sized pot

A chopping board

A cheese grater

A sharp knife

A whisk

A small mixing bowl





Method

1. Chop onion or shallot finely.
2. Blanch green beans by bringing them to the boil in a pot filled with salt water (2T salt for 1L water). Add green beans to boiling water and leave for two minutes (or until beans are just cooked through, but still crisp).
3. While beans are blanching, prepare a bowl of ice water.
4. Remove beans from hot water with a slotted spoon and place in ice water to stop them cooking further.
5. Drain the green beans and add the finely chopped onion or shallot.



For vinaigrette

1. Combine the olive oil, lemon juice, garlic and mayonnaise in a bowl. Whisk until thoroughly mixed.
2. Toss vinaigrette and Parmesan cheese over the beans and onions.
3. Refrigerate until ready to serve.



HONEY AND THYME BREAD

Preparation time: 10 mins

Cooking time: 40 mins

Ingredients

- 750ml self-raising flour
- 5ml (1 tsp) fine salt
- 125ml (½ cup) honey
- 5ml (1 tsp) fresh or dried thyme (can be substituted with rosemary)
- 2 eggs, beaten
- 45ml (3T) melted butter

What else you will need

- A mixing bowl
- A medium-sized bread pan

Method

1. Pre-heat oven to 180°C.
2. Mix dry ingredients together in a bowl with a spoon.
3. Once mixed, stir in eggs and honey.
4. Use half the butter to grease the inside of a bread pan.
5. Pour bread batter into pan and spread evenly.
6. Brush the remaining butter over the top of the bread batter.
7. Garnish with fresh thyme and place in the oven.
8. Bake for approximately 40-45 minutes (the bread should pull away from the sides of the pan and sound hollow when tapped).



9. Remove bread from the pan and place on a cooling rack.
10. Serve with butter and preserves of your choice.

FILLET OF BEEF STUFFED WITH MUSHROOMS AND FETA

Preparation time: 20 mins

Cooking time: 1 hour

Ingredients

- 1 punnet porcini mushrooms, sliced
- 1 onion, finely diced
- 2 feta cheese wheels, crumbled
- 30ml (2T) olive oil
- 5ml (1 tsp) crushed garlic
- 2 fresh rosemary sprigs, chopped
- 1,5kg beef fillet

For pepper sauce

- 15ml (1T) butter
- 500ml (2 cups) cream
- 1,5T peppercorns
- 5ml (1 tsp) Maizena
- Salt to taste



What else you will need

- 2 pans
- Braai tongs
- Foil
- A chopping board
- The fire should be prepared as coals are needed.

Method for stuffing

1. Fry mushrooms, onions and garlic in a pan and cool slightly.
2. Add feta cheese and rosemary sprigs.
3. Use a sharp knife to make a

lengthwise cut, about three-quarters deep, in the side of the beef (don't cut all the way through).

4. Open the beef so that it lies flat on the chopping board. Spread the stuffing mixture over the meat.
5. Roll the meat up tightly into a log and cover with foil (shiny side inside).
6. Place the meat on the coals and turn occasionally. (Meat should cook about 35 mins for rare steak, 45 mins for medium and 50 for well done.)
7. Remove foil and allow the meat to rest for 10 mins before serving.

Method for pepper sauce

1. In a pan, add butter and peppercorns. Fry for three minutes.
2. Add cream to the pan, leaving a little in which to dissolve Maizena.
3. Add Maizena mixture.
4. Stir continuously until sauce has thickened slightly.



Anri Fourie, owner of two guesthouses and mom of an eight-year-old daughter and four-year-old triplets, cooks meals that are quick and easy to make – with multiple little helping hands. In the Fourie household, family time is a great time to cook together. As the former owner of a coffee shop, Anri used to share the kitchen with skilled chefs. Today she shares it with her four busy little offspring, who're all eager to pitch in and help.

5. Season with salt.
6. Cut beef fillet into medallions and pour pepper sauce over them.





Braai safety tips for kids

Kids are naturally curious about their surroundings and will take every opportunity available to explore them. Here are some vital safety tips when having a braai around children:

- When operating an open-fire grill near kids, there should always be an adult whose sole duty is to watch the children's movement and supervise what they're doing.
- Cuts and scratches are among the most common braai-related injuries. It's



advisable to cover edges and pointy protrusions of them braai with masking tape unless the area will be exposed to heat.

- In order to prevent the kids feeling left out, involve them in the food preparation. They can help prepare and carry the food outside to be grilled while the coals are getting hot.
- Using accelerants is highly discouraged where kids are involved. Accelerants such as

paraffin and petrol should never be used around children.

- Once the braai is lit, it should never be left unattended or moved. Kids may take advantage of this to satisfy their curiosity, which could lead to injuries. Pets like dogs should also be kept away from the area, particularly if kids are exciting them and making them run.
- Once done, the grill shouldn't be moved or touched until it's cooled down completely. The ashes should be taken to an appropriate place.

Braaiing is always an exciting and fun activity for the whole family. These safety tips will help ensure a positive experience for all of you!

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Hearing is what keeps us in touch with our world. It plays a significant role in expressing and receiving language. Many children are flagged as having learning, language and behavioural challenges when, in reality, they have hearing loss. It can affect their ability to develop speech, language and social skills, which can lead to educational problems.

Most hearing losses are identified through screening at birth, but some children aren't diagnosed until later, when speech or language skills aren't progressing. According to the Centres for Disease Control & Prevention, about 15% of children aged six to 19 have hearing loss of at least 16 decibels in one or both ears. Around 0,1% have severe hearing loss.

Research done by the American Speech-Language Hearing Association indicated that children

In kids, hearing loss can mimic learning disorders

Hearing loss can affect a child's development of speech and language skills. When a child has difficulty hearing, the areas of the brain used for communication may not develop appropriately. This makes talking, understanding and learning very difficult

with mild to moderate hearing loss who don't get help are very likely to be behind their hearing peers.

Even if not in a traditional classroom environment, certain subjects are intrinsically more difficult for a child with hearing loss. While the ability to hear affects most aspects of academic achievement, perhaps the areas most affected are those involving

language concepts. Vocabulary, language arts, sentence structure and idiomatic expressions are extremely difficult for a child affected by hearing loss to grasp.

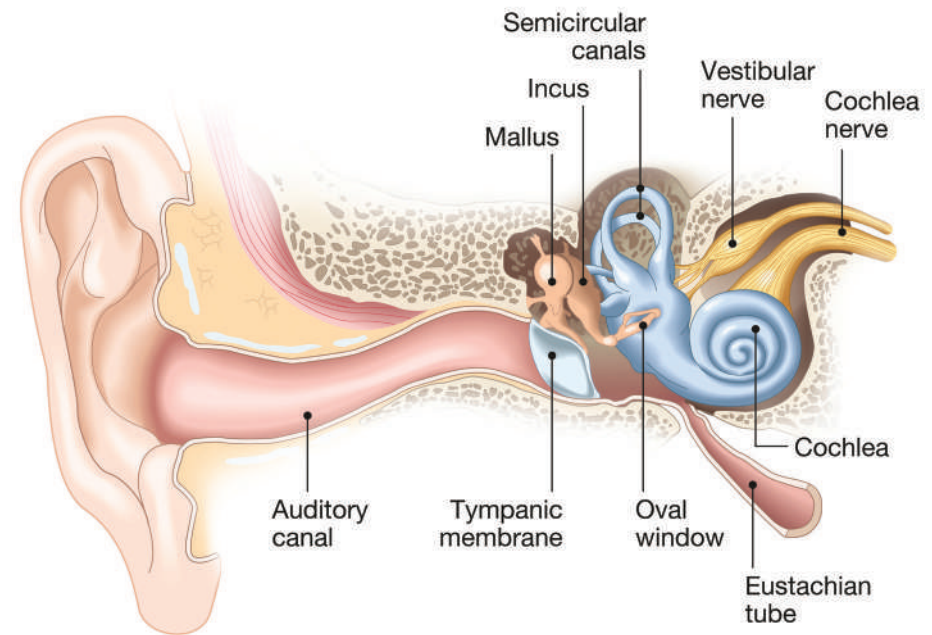
Frustration and confusion can also play a big part in poor academic performance. Though they might have perfectly normal speech, children with only mild hearing loss can still have trouble hearing

a teacher or educator amid background noise.

Children with hearing loss lose access to a great deal of information from the conversations around them every day. Many words sound the same to them, so they're forced to expend a great deal of effort trying to distinguish what's being said. The extra listening effort is required constantly and can quickly lead to fatigue for the child, which could affect their motivation for learning.

In addition to academic struggles in school, children with hearing loss can experience trouble socially. Communication is vital to social interactions and healthy peer relationships; without the ability to communicate effectively, they often experience feelings of isolation and unhappiness.

If a child with hearing loss is excluded from social interactions



or is unwilling to participate in group activities due to fear of embarrassment, they can become socially withdrawn, leading to further misery. It's also important to remember that hearing-impaired individuals are often teased. People tend to get annoyed having to repeat themselves and often yell in order to be understood. For this reason, hearing loss is also a

very emotionally stressful sensory impairment.

Signs that a child has hearing loss include having limited or unclear speech, not following directions or paying attention, hearing only parts of a conversation, asking for information to be repeated and not being able to hear everyday sounds. There are differing degrees

“Children with hearing loss lose access to a great deal of information from the conversations around them every day. Many words sound the same to them, so they’re forced to expend a great deal of effort trying to distinguish what’s being said.”



of hearing loss, referred to as mild, moderate, severe and profound.

What causes hearing loss?

- Family history of hearing loss.
- Chromosomal differences.
- Anatomical differences.
- Syndromes.
- Prenatal drug or alcohol use.
- Medication used in serious medical situations.
- Prematurity.
- Illness or injury.
- Loud noise (sometimes this exposure is sudden and short-term).
- Hearing loss can also be unexplained.

If you think your child may have some degree of hearing loss, the good news is that there are now more hearing technologies than ever before which can help improve not just their school performance, but their overall quality of life.

The most important thing is to have them tested as soon as you suspect there may be a problem. The sooner you can determine the cause and level of loss, the faster your child can be on their way to hearing the world in a whole new way.

There's been substantial progress in assistive technology and support services that offer individuals with

hearing loss a much wider range of options to choose from to facilitate their lives. Treatments include:

Hearing assist devices: These devices help restore hearing. Hearing aids

are worn on or inside the ear to amplify sound. Healthcare providers surgically implant cochlear implants into the inner ear to treat inner-ear hearing loss.

Hearing rehabilitation: Also called audiologic rehabilitation, this therapy helps a person adjust to hearing loss and hearing aids. A



therapist can also help them learn to use visual cues and lip-reading to improve communication.

Listening devices: Devices can make it easier to hear the telephone, television or videos on your computer.

Medications: Hearing loss caused by ear infections may improve with antibiotics. Corticosteroids can ease the swelling of cochlear hair cells after exposure to loud noise. If medications are causing your child's hearing loss, your provider may prescribe a different drug.

Surgery: Your provider may place ear tubes in the eardrum. Ear tubes treat chronic middle-ear infections that contribute to hearing loss. Providers also perform surgeries to remove tumours, repair birth defects and place cochlear implants.

Undiagnosed and untreated hearing loss can have an impact similar to a learning or behavioural disorder. However, once the condition's been treated, kids with hearing loss are just as capable as their peers.





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Must-read series for young leaders

As we prepare to celebrate Heritage Day in South Africa, John Pampallis, editor of the book series *They Fought for Freedom*, explains why it's important to create relevant and local history resources for children



What inspired you to create the series? I've taught in SA, Botswana, Canada and Tanzania. This includes eight years at the Solomon Mahlangu Freedom College (Somafo) in Tanzania, a school for young South African exiles. From 1989-2015, I was involved in education policy development and was later an advisor to the Minister of Higher Education & Training. While teaching at Somafo, I came across a series of short biographies of leaders of the anti-colonial movements for independence in Africa. Included in that series were people like Patrice Lumumba (Congo), Julius Nyerere (Tanzania), Jomo Kenyatta (Kenya) and Kwame Nkrumah (Ghana). I immediately realised how valuable that kind

of publication could be for young South Africans and began to visualise what such a series might look like.

What are the unique components or features that make this publication special for a young reader? In working towards the series' goal of uncovering the past, it was important that whatever material was developed was pitched at the right level for young people, but written in a non-patronising way. *They Fought for Freedom* was pitched at pupils in secondary school and was also suitable for other readers who wanted a short overview of the lives of leaders of the past, including those who were still feeling their way through the intricacies of the English language.

Another objective of the series was to present accurate history – reality, not hagiography. I believe we succeeded in that.

What would you like young readers to take away from the books? An understanding not only of the individuals the books portray, but of their country and the world. I also hope they realise that leaders aren't only famous individuals, but include those who played a role in the struggle for freedom. In addition, the lives of the individuals portrayed in the series show that service to one's people is more important than self-aggrandisement – a lesson many in the public eye today should take to heart.

The series was published about 25 years ago. Why is it still as

relevant as ever today? We face many of the same problems now that we did 25 years ago. Children and young adults, even the population at large, have similar needs and face similar challenges. And there's still a dearth of knowledge about SA's past and the sacrifices that were made to enable today's democracy.

Many of the individuals in the series weren't famous at the time (or now). Though they did important work and showed tremendous courage, they weren't well known outside their organisations. Even the details of the lives (especially the early lives) of those whose names are widely known today, and who have monuments and streets dedicated to them, are usually unknown. There's a need for powerful role models for young people.

Another important factor is the need to encourage a culture of reading among youth. The best way of doing that is by providing them with material that interests them, that isn't too long and that's relatively easy for them to read. We believe that the books in this series provide just that.

While the books are pitched at high school students, they're also of interest to general adult readers looking for an easy way to learn about the individuals who played an important role in their country's history.



More about *They Fought for Freedom*

They Fought for Freedom is a unique series covering the lives and exploits of southern African leaders who struggled for freedom and justice. The accessible writing is accompanied by relevant photographs and stimulating activities, making these books ideal for use at home, in classrooms, libraries or resource centres.

The series consists of 18 titles covering the lives and exploits of Chief Albert Luthuli, Chris Hani, David Webster, Archbishop Emeritus Desmond Tutu, Dora Tamana, Helen Suzman, Lilian Ngoyi, Mohandas (Mahatma) Gandhi (the South African years), Nelson Mandela, Oliver Tambo, Ruth First, Sir Seretse Khama, Sol Plaatje, Steve Biko, Thabo Mbeki, Trevor Manuel, Yusuf Dadoo and ZK Matthews.

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